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Nielsen Norman Group

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

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Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

Evaluator:
Date:
Product:
Task:

1 Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

Although PawTrack is still a prototype, it already gives users a basic idea of what is happening in the system. Users can see appointment details, vaccination status, confirmation prompts, and active navigation indicators. These features help guide users while using the app. However, some feedback could still be clearer, especially after important actions such as booking or canceling an appointment.

Recommendations

Future versions can include more noticeable success messages, loading indicators, or short status updates after users complete an action. This would help users feel more confident that the system has responded properly.

2 Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

The prototype mostly uses familiar pet-care terms, such as pet profile, vaccination record, and appointment. These words are easy for users to understand. However, during the evaluation, some respondents had difficulty understanding formal terms in the SUS questionnaire, such as “cumbersome,” “well integrated,” and “unnecessarily complex.”

Recommendations

Since the SUS questionnaire is standardized, the questions should not be changed. Instead,us, the researchers can explain difficult words in simpler terms before the respondents answer. For the prototype itself, the app should continue using simple and familiar words that pet owners can easily understand.

3

User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is Undo and Redo supported?

Issues

Most users can navigate the prototype without much difficulty. They can go back to previous screens and cancel some actions. However, because this is still a prototype, undo and redo features are limited. This means users may not always be able to correct an action after submitting or confirming information.

Recommendations

Future versions of the application may consider implementing undo and redo functionalities, along with additional confirmation prompts or editable forms, to improve user control and allow users to correct mistakes more efficiently during system interaction.

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

The prototype generally feels consistent. The buttons, icons, layouts, and navigation patterns are similar across the screens, which makes the app easier to understand. Users do not need to relearn how to use each screen because the design follows common mobile app patterns.

Recommendations

The design should continue using consistent colors, icons, labels, buttons, and screen layouts. As more screens are added in the future, they should follow the same style so the app remains familiar and easy to navigate.

5

Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

The prototype helps prevent some mistakes by showing confirmation prompts before important actions, such as canceling an appointment. This gives users time to review their decision before continuing. However, since the prototype is not yet a complete system, it may still lack full input validation or warnings for all possible errors.

Recommendations

Future versions can include required-field reminders, clear input instructions, and warning messages before users submit important information. These features would help prevent mistakes before they happen.

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

Most of the important information in the prototype is easy to see. Users can recognize vaccination records, appointment details, form fields, and navigation options without needing to memorize many steps. However, the “Add Booking” icon may not be noticeable enough because one respondent needed help finding it.

Recommendations

The “Add Booking” button or icon should be easier to find. This can be done by increasing its size, improving its contrast, adding a clear label, or placing it in a more visible area of the screen.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

7

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and funtionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

The prototype supports basic mobile interactions, such as tapping and navigating through screens. It also includes personalized information, such as pet profiles, vaccination records, and appointment details. However, advanced shortcuts are not yet included, which is understandable because the prototype mainly focuses on showing the main user flow.

Recommendations

Future versions can include quick-access features, such as a booking shortcut, saved pet details, or faster access to frequently used functions. These improvements would make the app more convenient, especially for returning users.

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnescessary elements been removed?

Issues

The prototype has a clean and simple design. It focuses on the most important information and does not overwhelm users with too many elements. This makes the app easier to use and more comfortable to navigate.

Recommendations

The app should maintain its simple and organized design. Future improvements can focus on better spacing, alignment, font consistency, and visual hierarchy while keeping the interface clean and uncluttered.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

9 Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

The prototype includes basic confirmation and cancellation prompts, which help users avoid accidental actions. However, it does not yet provide detailed error messages or step-by-step instructions for fixing mistakes. This is understandable because the prototype mainly demonstrates the design and flow, not the full system functionality.

Recommendations

Future versions can include clearer error messages, highlighted fields, and simple instructions on how to fix errors. This would help users recover from mistakes without feeling confused.

10 Help and Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

The prototype does not yet include a help section, tutorial, FAQ, or searchable guide. Although most users may still complete the main tasks, first-time users might need extra guidance, especially once the app becomes more complete.

Recommendations

The researchers may add simple onboarding screens, FAQs, user guides, or small helpful tips within the app. These features would make PawTrack easier to understand, especially for new users.